Neurology Service Line Handbook

MERIDIAN HEALTH PARTNERS ## OPERATIONAL POLICY MANUAL: NEUROLOGY SERVICE LINE Document ID: MHP-POL-NEU-014 Effective Date: January 15, 2024 Applies To: All Neurology Department Personnel, Referral Coordinators, and Patient Access Staff across all 14 Meridian Health Partners sites. Policy Lead: Dr. Aris Thorne, Chief of Clinical Operations

1. PURPOSE AND SCOPE 1.1 This document establishes the operational parameters, intake criteria, scheduling durations, insurance coverage tiers, and referral processing standards for the Neurology service line at all 14 Meridian Health Partners outpatient clinics. 1.2 Compliance with these clauses is mandatory for all administrative and clinical support staff. Departures from these operational thresholds require written authorization from the Department Administrator, Marcus Vance.

2. CONDITIONS ACCEPTED AND EXPLICITLY NOT ACCEPTED 2.1 Accepted Conditions: The Neurology department accepts adult and adolescent patients (ages 16 and older) presenting with chronic headache disorders (including refractory migraine), primary seizure disorders, peripheral neuropathies, essential tremor, early-stage cognitive impairment, and non-acute movement disorders. 2.2 Explicitly Not Accepted: The department does not accept patients presenting with acute stroke symptoms within the 24-hour therapeutic window, acute spinal cord trauma, active neurosurgical emergencies, pediatric neurology cases under the age of 16, or patients requiring mechanical ventilation or continuous inpatient monitoring. 2.3 Redirection Protocol: Patients presenting with conditions listed in Clause 2.2 must be immediately redirected to the nearest tertiary hospital emergency department by front desk personnel or triage nurses.

3. APPOINTMENT DURATION AND SCHEDULING THRESHOLDS 3.1 New Patient Consultations: Allocated a standard duration of 60 minutes. This includes 45 minutes of face-to-face clinical evaluation and 15 minutes for documentation and care plan entry. 3.2 Follow-Up Appointments: Allocated a standard duration of 30 minutes. 3.3 Diagnostic Procedure Slots: Electroencephalogram (EEG) setup and recording appointments are standardized at 90 minutes per patient session. Nerve Conduction Studies (NCS) and Electromyography (EMG) combined procedures are allotted 75 minutes. 3.4 Buffer Requirements: Providers must maintain a minimum 10-minute administrative buffer between all scheduled clinical encounters.

4. PATIENT PREPARATION INSTRUCTIONS 4.1 Routine Neurological Consultations: Patients must bring a complete medication list, including over-the-counter supplements, and prior neuroimaging discs or reports dated within the past 24 months. 4.2 EEG Preparation: Patients scheduled for an EEG must wash their hair the evening prior to the appointment using a basic shampoo. Hair styling products, oils, sprays, and conditioners are strictly prohibited on the day of the test. Patients scheduled for sleep-deprived EEGs must restrict their sleep to a maximum of 3 hours the night prior to the procedure. 4.3 NCS/EMG Preparation: Patients undergoing NCS or EMG must take a bath or shower on the day of the test to remove skin oils. Lotions, creams, and body oils must not be applied to the limbs being tested. Patients taking anticoagulant medications must notify the scheduling desk 5 business days prior to the procedure.

5. INSURANCE COVERAGE TIERS ACROSS MERIDIAN PLANS 5.1 Meridian CarePlus (Plan A): Covers routine neurology consultations and standard EEGs in full, subject to a $25 copay. NCS/EMG procedures require prior authorization and carry a 20% coinsurance. Advanced neuroimaging (MRI/MRA Brain) is covered only after a documented trial of first-line pharmacotherapy fails. 5.2 Meridian Select (Plan B): Covers routine consultations, follow-ups, and all diagnostic EEGs and NCS/EMG procedures with a $15 copay. Prior authorization is waived for outpatient electrodiagnostic testing ordered by a Meridian-credentialed neurologist. 5.3 Meridian Value (Plan C): Covers routine consultations with a $40 copay. Diagnostic procedures (EEG and NCS/EMG) are subject to a $150 deductible followed by 30% coinsurance. Out-of-network referrals are completely excluded from coverage under Plan C. 5.4 Meridian Direct (Plan D): Provides direct access to neurology consultations without a primary care referral, subject to a $50 copay. EEGs are fully covered; however, NCS/EMG procedures require a pre-service clinical review by the utilization management team, managed by Nurse Supervisor Brenda Gomez.

6. REFERRAL TURNAROUND COMMITMENT 6.1 Standard Referrals: The Neurology department commits to processing all routine incoming referral packets within 48 business hours of receipt. Processing includes clinical triage, insurance verification, and generation of the patient outreach queue. 6.2 Urgent Referrals: Referrals marked as urgent by the primary care provider must be triaged by a registered nurse within 4 business hours, with direct patient contact initiated within 24 calendar hours to secure an appointment slot within 7 business days. 6.3 Unresponsive Patients: If the patient cannot be reached after three telephone outreach attempts executed across 3 consecutive business days, the referral file is placed in suspended status and the originating provider is notified via the Meridian Electronic Health Record portal.

End of Document. Approved by Dr. Aris Thorne, Chief of Clinical Operations.